



## CHAPTER 8: GAMEMASTERING

*There is in all things a pattern that is part of our universe. It has symmetry, elegance, and grace—those qualities you find always in that which the true artist captures. You can find it in the turning of the seasons, in the way sand trails along a ridge, in the branch clusters of the creosote bush or the pattern of its leaves. We try to copy these patterns in our lives and our society, seeking the rhythms, the dances, the forms that comfort. Yet, it is possible to see peril in the finding of ultimate perfection. It is clear that the ultimate pattern contains its own fixity. In such perfection, all things move toward death.*

—from *The Collected Sayings of Muad'Dib*, by Princess Irulan

# WHAT DOES THE GAMEMASTER DO?

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Are you ready to run the world? As the gamemaster, you are the ultimate player. You control every chatty assassin, desperate water seller, and snarky smuggler your players interact with. You command the winds of Arrakis and determine if they snap the blades of the players' ornithopter, sending them spiraling down to the scorching sands to face the sandworms and leaving them to a slow slog across the burning face of Dune... or not. It really is all up to you.

## THE GAMEMASTER'S JOB IS TO...

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The gamemaster is the tour guide, the glue that binds the characters together, and the motivation that gets players to make interesting decisions. It's not an easy job, but it is a fun one! In the end, the goal is to have a fun time and have great experiences with your players.

### ...BE A TEAM PLAYER.

As the gamemaster, you are the primary storyteller, and your players are your creative collaborators. You are shepherding your players through a harsh, exciting world and a thrilling story that is very possibly of your own creation. Your players may make decisions that might take you all in unexpected directions. Together, you're creating a unique experience, a story in the *Dune* universe that belongs only to you and your players, no one else. You are all a team.

### ...CREATE AND MANAGE THE CAMPAIGN.

You can choose to use a pre-made campaign or create one from scratch. Your campaign might take only a single session or turn into a multi-year epic. The non-player characters, the risks and rewards for the player characters, and the pacing of your campaign are all up to you. You can find tips and tricks for adventures and the size and length of campaigns in the **Creating an Adventure** section on p.221 and the **Short Games and Long-term Campaigns** section on p.219.

### ...KEEP THE GAME ENJOYABLE.

While you can expect intense drama in the *Dune* universe, you and your players should always feel comfortable. Talk to your players before you start your adventure together to make sure that you know everyone's boundaries and what topics are sensitive within your group. The respect and consideration between players and gamemasters start before a game even begins. See **Consent and Managing Group Comfort Levels** on p.232.

### ...HAVE FUN!

All of the above points have the potential to lead to a game where you and your players can work together to create a completely new tale of spacefaring adventurers daring to rise up against the Landsraad or facing the cruel environment of Arrakis. And have a good time doing it.

## THE GAMEMASTER'S JOB IS NOT TO...

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### ..."BEAT" THE PLAYER CHARACTERS.

Even though you control the endless enemies, the scheming villains, and the characters' antagonists, you are not the players' antagonist. Telling a great story together is the goal of a role-playing game. It is a collaboration with incredible results. You don't win if your players 'lose'.

### ...MAKE EVERYTHING TOO EASY.

However, that doesn't mean you can't provide a challenge! Pushing your players to the brink and having them come back in a dramatic fashion is rewarding for everyone involved. It also doesn't mean that your players' characters can't die—the Imperium is a brutal place, after all. Killing characters isn't the goal, though. Telling a good story is.

## QUICK TIPS

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### FLEXIBILITY IS KEY.

It's totally acceptable to go off script. Change the rules. Prepare to swap out your plans to make things more fun. For hints and tips, see **Running the Game** on p.226.

### NOT EVERYONE IS THE KWISATZ HADERACH...

But a player might want to experience what it's like to be the Chosen One every now and then. It's nice to make players feel extra special on occasion. Remember, they're on your storytelling team, not your nemeses.

### DON'T DEMAND IMPROVISATION FROM YOUR PLAYERS.

Some players are great at describing how their character's sharp tongue got the social edge at that banquet by convincing that courtier to admit to cheating water sellers out of profits. Encourage that!

However, some players haven't honed that skill or aren't comfortable thinking up explanations in the heat of the moment. And that's fine. If they rolled well and don't want to expand upon it, you can just explain that their character got the upper hand, leaving the poor courtier to pick up the pieces of their now-tattered reputation. Maybe the player will be more confident adding narration next time.

## EVERYONE PANICS.

### GAMEMASTERS, ESPECIALLY!

Creative blocks happen. Getting flustered and not being able to improvise is normal. Try not to let it get you down. If you've already prepared a one-off that you can slot in anywhere, you can try that. See **Running the Game** on p.226.

Sometimes, it helps to take a small break. Grab a sip of water. Or step out of the room and get something to eat. If that doesn't help, you can always end the session. Leaving your players on a cliffhanger and dying to know what happens next isn't a bad thing. Suspense is an effective storytelling tool!

# SHORT GAMES VS. LONG TERM CAMPAIGNS

Exploring the world of *Dune* means addressing its awesome sense of scale. Even its very name conjures images of vast, desolate lands. From the deserts of Arrakis to the great emptiness of space, a player character is a single, fragile individual surviving dangers posed by planetary environments and politics alike. In the face of this, you may feel overwhelmed, uncertain where to begin, or how long to play. Some stories are tightly-plotted mysteries slowly revealed over several game sessions. Other stories are isolated, stand-alone adventures. One way you can manage your game from the start is by defining the scope of the game and its length.

## SCOPE

Just as **Chapter 6: Conflict** breaks down conflict scope into smaller phases, a gamemaster can better manage a game by defining its setting scope. By establishing the boundaries of the story, you establish expectations for your players. A story set in the city of Arrakeen is different than one that travels between planets in the Imperium. For clarity, you can break scope down into three spheres: **local**, **world**, and **galaxy**.

### LOCAL

Set within a single environment such as a sietch, spaceship, or city, local games have limited scope, but are great for short sessions and new groups of players. Local games can introduce new material while creating conflicts that feel vital and personal. Every player character and non-player character is an essential piece of a larger puzzle with the capacity to affect everyone else involved.

Heists, murder mysteries, origin stories, small-scale political intrigues, and turf wars can serve as the nugget of your local game idea. Games with local scope can answer establishing questions for your players in a more interactive way than just telling them what is going on in the world. What if players learned about the governing authority via a heist or political intrigue? Would an origin story set on a frigate help acclimate your players to the tone of *Dune*? Or could a courier plot, forcing the characters to deliver a highly prized artifact, teach your players about the culture of a city?

The key to a local game is remembering that less is more. For some examples:

- ✧ Within a royal palace, servants find a high-ranking noble assassinated. As security locks down the palace to prevent the perpetrator from escaping, the player characters become prime suspects. Innocent, they must clear their names or find the real assassin.
- ✧ The planetary governor hires the player characters to protect a spice shipment traveling from Carthag to Arrakeen. But when spice smugglers descend on the transport, they sabotage the carryall. The vehicle crashes some 20 kilometers outside the capital with worms on the horizon.

### WORLD GAME

A world game has multiple locations in a single planet. And with a few exceptions, *Dune* is a world story with most of it taking place on Arrakis. The characters in the book explore distinct environments from the streets of Arrakeen to the caverns of Sietch Tabr. Getting from locale to locale requires flying an ornithopter or riding a sandworm. Each area has its own authority, such as a Fremen naib or a governor. Whereas a local game may have been bound by the limits of a single environment, the world game expands the scope of the story to include these settings.

War stories, diplomatic missions, action-adventure plots, and expeditions are a few types of games suited to the world setting. Conflicts featured in world games tend to involve larger groups of people like cultures at odds with each other, divided by ethnic or political ideologies, locked in a state of civil unrest. The challenges player characters face often change the fate of an entire society.

The key to a world game is creating opportunities for players to go globetrotting.

- ✧ On the planet Poritrin, player characters discover spies from a rival House. The spies lead the group on a fast-paced chase from Starda, the capital city, to the Isana River and into a secret underground facility.
- ✧ In order to kidnap a Bene Gesserit trainee from the Chapterhouse on Wallach IX, the player characters infiltrate the Chapterhouse itself, no small achievement.

## GALAXY GAME

A galaxy game spans the Known Universe and brings with it a sense of expanse and wonder. Galaxy games shine when paired with lengthy campaigns chronicling the lives of the player characters. That said, galaxy games can also work in shorter stories when time is of the essence: A controversial noble must reach a summit on a specific day, or Houses across the galaxy race against one another to obtain a priceless artifact.

Quests, pursuit and rescue plots, galaxy-spanning space operas, large-scale political intrigues, and galactic war stories can send player characters to the ends of the Known Universe and back again. You can make use of the Spacing Guild, traveling from planet to planet on Heighliners to explore established worlds, or even create your own. In galaxy games, character objectives can alter the course of history.

Galaxy games should feel epic.

- ❖ The player characters embark on a journey to find a long-lost sibling. Picking up clues from spice smugglers on Arrakis, their quest takes them first to the slave auction houses on Poritrin and eventually leads to the gladiatorial pits on Giedi Prime.
- ❖ A collector offers the player characters a job tracking down the personal journals of a Butlerian Jihad veteran. Scattered throughout the Known Universe are filmbooks, the hunt for which takes them from world to world as they unravel the secrets of each location.

## LENGTH

Games range in length from one-shot events to long-term campaigns. Take a book, for example. They range in length from short stories to novels to grand trilogies. A story told by a gamemaster is no different. You choose the length based on the story you want to tell. As a general guide, a one-shot adventure has only one or two major plot points or objectives whereas a multi-session campaign could have dozens.

- ❖ **Example (One-shot):** Break out of a brig. The first scene takes place inside the brig and allows the player characters an opportunity to get to know each other. The second scene is their escape. The story ends with them safely reaching a neutral port.
- ❖ **Example (Three-chapter Arc):** Kaitain hosts a summit for the Major Houses to discuss a major shortfall in CHOAM profits. The first session focuses on the summit, revealing potential suspects for financial theft. The second session leads them to the suspects' home worlds to gather evidence. And the third session has them confront those responsible.
- ❖ **Example (Nine-chapter Arc):** A conspiracy of nine rival nobles overthrow the baroness of a Major House. Each game session focuses on hunting down and dealing with a member of the conspiracy. Each member resides in a separate location, complete with its own troubles and complications.



# CREATING AN ADVENTURE

This is where things get exciting. What kind of adventure are you going to run for your players? What CHOAM conspiracies will you weave? What kinds of dangers do your characters face as they travel across the Imperium?

Don't feel like you must come up with everything from scratch... unless, of course, you want to. Every game-master has their own style. You have lots of options that give you the chance to tailor an adventure to your specifications, even if you're pressed for time.

## WHAT IS A PUBLISHED CAMPAIGN?

A published campaign is one that has the storyline, stats, and the antagonist(s) all plotted out for you. Basically, it has most of the work done for you. As the **Dune: Adventures in the Imperium** line continues, there will be several published adventures and even a campaign to support your game.

If you're looking for something really thorough that does a great job of supporting gamemasters who don't have the time to alter a campaign to their liking or aren't comfortable running an adventure yet, then the **Heirs of Dune** box set is a fantastic option. It comes with a campaign that introduces the rules to players and gamemasters as well offering an exciting adventure.

Some other published campaigns allow for more flexibility in player agency and customization. Read some reviews to find a published campaign that meets your needs.

## TIPS FOR USING PUBLISHED CAMPAIGNS

### READ IT FIRST.

Unless the published campaign is a starter set that specifies that it's playable right out of the box with no preparation needed, then it's helpful to read through the whole campaign before you start playing it. Basically, knowing what's coming up and the different options the players have is helpful when pivoting during a game.

### GET ORGANIZED.

Take notes. Get a feel for the non-player characters. Bookmark the different confrontations and items you think you might need to reference quickly. Feel free to create your own maps or reference materials for your players to keep on hand, too. As you become more experienced and get to know your particular player group's play style, you'll get a better feel for what you might want to provide them.

### WING IT OR STICK TO THE BOOK?

Don't be afraid to improvise and create scenarios outside the published campaign. A published campaign is there to act as a guide for you in whatever capacity you want.

If your players are doing the unexpected and the campaign doesn't account for that and you don't want to make up scenarios on your own, feel free to rein your players in a bit and redirect them back to the campaign's goals. See **Creating Non-player characters** on p.263 for tips on how to use non-player characters to get your players back on track.

## CREATING YOUR OWN CAMPAIGN

Rub your hands together in villainous, gamemaster glee. When you're creating your own campaign, you can make it whatever you want. Your players can try to pull off a heist, solve a mystery, try to ferret out secret information, perform daring rescues, and more.

There are a million ways to design a campaign, but a couple of the easiest are to start with a story hook and your villain's motivations.

### WHAT'S IN A STORY HOOK?

The most basic story hook has a goal for the players, indicates some of the risks, and hints at a reward. A story hook also often includes a non-player character with a little background, what that character wants to achieve, and how the player characters can get involved.

Here's a story hook that could turn into a bigger campaign:

*One of the Houses Minor is accusing Pinta, a water-seller in Arrakeen, of peddling poisoned water. She insists that she's innocent. The House Minor is willing to pay for evidence (real or fabricated) of her crimes. Pinta fears retaliation from the House Minor and doesn't have much to her name, but, for anyone who helps her prove that the poisoned water wasn't hers, she is willing to part with a map that's said to lead to an ancient treasure hidden in the sands.*

This story hook provides two sides and the rewards that each side is offering. The players could help Pinta or they could go for the big payday and help the House Minor.

### WHAT DOES YOUR VILLAIN WANT?

This is when the classic 'Who, What, When, Why, Where, How' style questions can help. Answer these questions about your villain to find their motivations.

- Who are they?
- What are they after?
- When do they plan on making their move?
- Where is it?
- Why do they want whatever it is?
- How do they go about getting what they want?

## ROLL A STORY HOOK

Roll your d20 for each column to determine your random story hook. This is an easy way to get a quick campaign or session idea.

It works like this: the players characters must [Plot] [Goal] in the [Location] and defeat the [Hazard] for [Character].

For example, say you rolled a 1 on your d20 four times. Your plot hook would look like this:

*Your players' characters must break in and steal the Secret Data in the Warehouse and defeat the Sardaukar Soldiers for Bashira, the head of a House Minor's security.*

And, yes, 'The Desert' is both a potential location and a hazard. This is Arrakis, after all.

| ROLL  | PLOT                                            | GOAL                | LOCATION        | HAZARD             | CHARACTER                                     |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 1-4   | Break in and steal or kidnap the...             | Secret Data         | Warehouse       | Sardaukar Soldiers | Bashira, the head of a House Minor's security |
| 5-8   | Solve the mystery of the...                     | House Minor Heir    | Manor House     | Security Systems   | Kaunos, the merchant                          |
| 9-12  | Investigate the murder or destruction of the... | Artifact            | Sietch          | The Desert         | Anca, the Fremen stillsuit seller             |
| 13-16 | Cause the murder or destruction of the...       | Illegal Technology  | Smuggler's Base | The Spacing Guild  | Hegai, the smuggler                           |
| 17-20 | Rescue or recover the...                        | Secret Spice Stores | The Desert      | The Smugglers      | Akira, the ornithopter pilot                  |

Check out **Creating Non-player Characters** on p.263 for more hints and tips for making well-rounded villains that make great antagonists for your players to face.

You have a story hook and the villain's motivations. Now what?

Now, you have to figure out the how. If you know how things are happening, then that gives you flexibility because the players can find the 'how' several different ways.

*In the above example with Pinta the water-seller, it helps to know how her water was poisoned. Perhaps, it was poisoned in the merchant's warehouse before it ever even got to her. How can the players figure that out? They can inspect the warehouse and find evidence of poison. They can interrogate other water-sellers, and perhaps one admits to seeing someone sneaking out the warehouse late at night.*

Another couple of useful questions to ask are "Why are they doing this now?" and "What happens if they succeed?" The answers to these two questions can provide the urgency and stakes for the adventure.

By knowing the how of the scheme, you can figure out how to react to your players' actions. Determining how you want to guide the players doesn't have to happen right away. If you need some time to come up with something, postponing until the next session works, too.

## QUICK TIPS

### CREATING NON-PLAYER CHARACTERS

Non-player characters are lots of fun. To be prepared, have a whole bunch of random, quick **minor** non-player characters ready, so you can pull one out if your players do something unexpected.

You can always turn a Minor non-player character into a **notable** or even a **major** one at a later point in time if the players end up interacting with them a lot. It also helps to give your non-player characters strong motivations, so you understand where they're coming from as you play them. Check out **Creating Non-player Characters** on p.263 for more.

### CREATING LOCATIONS

If you have some specific locations in mind... jot down a couple notes describing them. Try to hit a variety of senses. What does it smell like? What are the ambient sounds? This helps to round out a place and make it feel more real.

In Pinta's story hook above, a warehouse is mentioned. Here are some example details you could provide. Notice the added sounds, smells, and other sensations in addition to the visuals.

**Describing the Warehouse:** “The doorseal hisses as you push your way into the warehouse. You blink as glowglobes flicker on, revealing container after container of water. The humid air makes it hard to breathe. As you inhale, the odor of mildew fills your noses. On one wall, the water reclamation unit thumps like it needs maintenance. Was Pinta’s water poisoned here?”

### ADDING VARIETY

They say that variety is the spice of life. Giving different types of characters the chance to save the day can really make a game extra special for a player, especially if you happen to design an event specifically to a player’s or player character’s strengths. As satisfying as a good brawl is, not everything has to end in a fight. Sprinkle in opportunities for combat, diplomacy, puzzles, and any other kind of challenge you can think of.

As you’re creating, also consider giving your players different ways to solve the same problems. For example, if they want to fight, have some soldiers ready for them. If they want to go about it peacefully, maybe have an option where they can appeal to a neutral party instead. It is always best to prepare for different contingencies—you never know exactly how they’ll approach a problem at any given time.

### ACCOMMODATING YOUR PLAYERS

The game shouldn’t make anyone feel uncomfortable. You’re all there to have fun. As you’re designing your campaign, keep in mind the boundaries that you and your players discussed in your Session 0 (see **Consent and Managing Group Comfort Levels** on p.232). Respect your players. You should also expect respect from your players, as well.

SAMPLE VILLAIN

## MALTHACE FERREYRA

**Who?** Malthace Ferreyra, a noble who leads a House Minor on Arrakis.

**What?** She wants to secure a CHOAM directorship for her House.

**When?** She has been patient for many years and is making her big move now.

**Where?** She lives and works on Arrakis but hopes to receive a siridar fief from the Emperor along with her CHOAM directorship.

**Why?** Her family has never had much influence due to their status as a powerless House Minor on Arrakis. They were always expected to support whoever had the planetary governorship. And Malthace has seen how every duke and baron who ran the siridar fiefdom has botched their command. She knows that she and her family could do a much better job.

**How?** Malthace believes she’s made a deal with a CHOAM representative. The massive mercantile organization is unhappy with the shares of melange they’re receiving from the current planetary governor. If Malthace can find a way to ruin the reputation of the Great House currently running Arrakis, her CHOAM contact believes that they can have the House exiled and transfer their directorship to Malthace’s House.



# SETTING UP A GAME

## ARRAKIS AWAITS!

If you're ready to rule over the shifting sands of Dune and the devious denizens of the Imperium as a game-master, you'll need some players, a Session 0 scheduled, and player characters.



## FINDING A GROUP TO PLAY WITH

Where does one unearth the kindred spirits who wholeheartedly dive into this adventure with you?

### REAL-LIFE FRIENDS

The *Dune* novels, movies, videogames, and board-games have touched a lot of lives and left a lot of fans in their wake over the years. Reach out to the people around you. You might be surprised just how many people you already know who heed the call of the spice trade.

### ONLINE

From social media to digital tools that allow you to play roleplaying games online, there are many resources to help you find or start a new game.

To start your recruitment drive, hunt for the 'Looking for Group' (LFG) sections of your favorite tabletop websites and online tools. Gamemasters are always in demand.

### FRIENDLY LOCAL GAME STORE (FLGS)

Tucked all around the world are wonderful stores that cater to the tabletop game crowd. Game stores often have tables for playing games. Sometimes, they even offer in-person pickup games, one-off adventures, or even specific days where a particular game is the focus.

You're likely to find fellow storytellers in places like these. And they might even let you put up a bulletin or recruit for a player group at the store. These little gems are amazing resources, and they're just a web search away.

### DUNE FANS

There are a lot of people, online and in person, who love *Dune* and the *Dune* universe. And even if those fans haven't played a roleplaying game before—many might just be willing to dive into a spice-filled escapade with you. So, wherever you can find *Dune* fans, you may very well find some players to join your adventure.

## MANAGING EXPECTATIONS

### SESSION 0

Session 0 is the first meeting (virtual or in person) you and your players can have before starting the adventure. And it's very important. This is the time when you'll all talk to each other and set boundaries. See **Consent and Managing Group Comfort Levels** on p.232.

Also, this is the time to work on characters together. Your players can either create their characters or become acquainted with any pre-generated characters. Some published campaigns come with pre-created player characters.

### SHORT CAMPAIGNS

When playing with a new group, it helps to start with a one-off adventure or a short campaign no more than a few sessions long (see **Short Games and Long-term Campaigns** on p.219). Starting small like this helps to make sure the group is compatible and gives everyone a chance to get comfortable with each other without a huge commitment.

If you do decide to go with a shorter adventure or campaign to begin with, communicate this to help manage your players' expectations. You may want to create new characters or continue with the ones you have. You may also find that players want to change their characters, based on their experience with the rules and the setting. While this is generally discouraged during a long-term campaign, this is the perfect time to do so, when things are just getting started. Just like the characters in a television series can change slightly between the pilot episode and those later in the season, so too can player characters. Players should not be forced to suffer the consequences of uninformed decisions during character creation that will linger throughout the rest of the campaign.

### INCOMPATIBILITY

Communication is key between players, and especially between the players and the gamemaster. See **Managing Personalities** on p.231 for tips on how to address many issues that may crop up within a group.

However, despite stellar communication and mitigation tactics, sometimes players and gamemasters have different styles that don't mesh. Sometimes, individual players want something different out of the game than do the other players in the group. On the more mundane side of things, life happens, which means schedules and priorities change. And, occasionally, a group just doesn't work out. This even happens to long-standing groups that have years of history together. And that's okay. Oftentimes, no one is to blame. Don't be too hard on yourself if this happens to your group.

That simply means it's time to go out, form a new group, and start telling brand new stories with a new team.

## TIPS FOR CREATING CHARACTERS WITH YOUR PLAYERS

When it's Session 0 time, your players should be creating their characters. Here's some advice.

### WORK TOGETHER

Why would a character work in a group? It makes it a lot easier on you to have your players determine how or why their characters would work in a group as they're creating them.

This is especially useful if a player wants to play a 'lone wolf' type of character who wouldn't normally work with others (a popular archetype). This way you and your players are less likely to get caught in complicated situations where everyone's having to come up with on-the-spot reasons for why the team doesn't split up or won't cooperate. The impetus can be money, a shared goal, a shared enemy, or even ideology.

### CREATE IMPERFECT CHARACTERS

As a gamemaster, you should lean into and reward quirks and flaws in the player characters. It fleshes them out and makes the sessions more fun and interesting. Take note especially of their weaknesses, as these are wonderful levels by which you can apply drama and conflict in the game, elements that feel personal to the player character.

### ALLOW UNBALANCED GROUPS

Unbalanced groups are fine! Maybe your players all want to play the same type, or no one wants to take any kind of first aid or medical ability. These types of unbalanced groups can be a fun to play, too.

You and your players should get creative with how they approach different situations. Certain options might close to them because their characters just can't solve a problem a specific way. It might lead to a different play style and gamemaster style to accommodate it. But it often leads to unexpected stories! Even if every player character in the group has a hammer, not every problem needs to look like a nail.

### THINK ABOUT CHARACTER DEATH

If you plan on running a brutal campaign with a lot of character deaths, it might help to have your players start thinking of backup characters early on. This way your players can start getting excited about their next character, and the death of their current character might not sting quite so much. Players can create all manner of minor characters that might act as agents for their main character and take up their mantle if something should happen to them. Fortunately, the House construction of play means that one can relatively easily bring another character to the fore, even one superficially similar to the prior one.

### FOSTER DIVERSITY

Encourage your players to play diverse characters of different races, religions, genders, sexualities, and abilities! See **Manage Diversity** on p.264 for tips on how to do this respectfully.

### PLANT STORY SEEDS

The characters your players create can provide a wealth of information. No background, however small, cannot offer a few plot hooks and story seeds of its own. What made them pledge their loyalty to the House? Who trained them and why? Where did they meet their contacts and how much can they trust them? How did they come by their assets, and did acquiring them pay a debt or incur one? A short discussion about background with the player group can often write whole adventures for you.

### ASK WHAT THE PLAYERS WANT

Finally, remember that the characters the players create tell you the sort of game they want to play. This is the easiest and most obvious form of player investment. A player who creates a socialite most likely wants a game featuring intrigue, one who creates a fighter wants action and combat. It is vital the gamemaster pays attention to this so they can make sure their adventures not only engage the players but give each character the chance to shine.

# RUNNING A GAME

After your players have character sheets, and you have tailored your story to their interests, it's time to run a game. Keep in mind, **Dune: Adventures in the Imperium** is a heavily narrative system. You should view the rules included in this book as tools to use at your discretion. Whether your players enjoy number-crunching and rolling dice, or defining success or failure with a simple Difficulty test, you can modify and interpret the system to best serve your story and your players' preferred play styles.

## THE FIRST SCENE

Do the players characters know each other? If not, the first scene should introduce them to each other in some interesting way. For example, an immediate problem they must solve as a team is one way, while using a notable non-player character to bring them together for a task is another.

Consider using a unifying objective for the player characters like fame, duty, or shared survival. Then, think about what sort of initial setting would best highlight the tone of the game. A story that starts in a bar suggests a casual, adventurous atmosphere. A story beginning with the baron giving a powerful monologue may encourage players to lean into the drama. A first scene with said baron dead on the floor evokes mystery and indicates player characters should gather clues and search for evidence.

Introductory scenes set expectations for your players. For example:

- ✧ In a holding cell on Giedi Prime, each player character has been arrested for the same crime, though none of them are actually responsible. Do they work together to prove their innocence or plan their escape?
- ✧ The player characters attend the wedding reception of two young nobles from rival houses joined in matrimony. The player characters have a chance to mingle and converse with each other while you set the tone for family drama and high political intrigue.
- ✧ The story opens with a chase scene. A trio of ornithopters pursue the player characters' carryall. This scenario drops them into the middle of an action adventure. Later scenes can explain how they reached this point, either through narration or even roleplaying them out.

## USING DRIVES

Drives can be one of the more challenging aspects of the system to use. While they offer an array of narrative and motivational options, and facilitate architect play, their very flexibility can prove confusing. However, you can use drives in several different ways to fine-tune the style of game to what suits your group.

Which drive should be used for a test is usually defined by the drive statements. The statements are designed to offer a quick narrative description of what a drive means to that character. This allows the player to define their own interpretation of the drive and forgo the need to check the definition of the drive in question before deciding.

However, some players find it more intuitive to start with the drive and see if the statement suits it, and that's fine. If the statements are less clear for your group, try asking them to look at which drive is appropriate instead of looking at the statements. Then, having chosen the correct drive they can see if their statement applies to the situation to allow the use of determination. You should use whichever way round your group finds intuitive, and each player can use a different style if everyone knows who is doing what.

When picking a drive, it is important to remember that they define the character's motivation and therefore the way they are being played. As such, the player should be allowed to have the final say on what suits their character. Having said that, the gamemaster can rule they have not justified the use of a particular drive enough and should either pick another or offer a better explanation. Picking a drive shouldn't turn into a long argument or be taken into too much depth. The gamemaster should simply ask the player why they are doing the action and see what they say and how that relates to drives and statements.

This can lead to players using the same drive, their best one, all the time. To a degree, this is fine. Characters can play to their strengths and their highest drive is the way they tend to meet most challenges. As elite agents of their House they are often working with a good chance of success. However, the gamemaster can insist a player consider other options. If they don't, the character's methods become predictable to their enemies and may offer an opportunity for the gamemaster to apply Threat. As a rule of thumb, a gamemaster might gain Threat each time a character uses a particular drive, if it is halfway through the session and they have used no other drives.

While it can seem cumbersome, it is worth taking the time to properly define a character's drive when making a test. It is easy to be overeager to grab the dice and get rolling. But in **Dune** a test can often become a game of cat-and-mouse as each side manages Threat and Momentum spends and applies traits and assets.

"The slow blade penetrates the shield", so take time to figure out the nature of each situation. A short discussion can offer new ideas for traits, Momentum spends, and narration for the scene, all of which offer greater roleplaying opportunities for the group. Knowing why they are doing something can offer the player characters much more agency and help craft their characters. Don't be too quick

to waste the opportunity, but at the same time be aware when the game is losing pace and getting bogged down.

When an action is important, motivation becomes easier. When breaking into a facility, it might be on behalf of the House (Duty) to save a friend (Faith) or right a wrong (Justice) to uncover a plot (Truth) or to prove the strength of your army (Power), etc. But when you are just picking a lock or trying to escape a downed ornithopter, your motivation doesn't seem very clear. You just need to get the job done or follow your orders.

There are two options in this situation. The first is for the gamemaster to ask the players what their character's reasons are for doing the mission at all, before they set out. They then all pick a drive that suits that motivation. For any minor tests involving the mission, this is the drive they use, representing their overall incentive. They can use other drives and statements as often as they wish. But if they are ever unsure what applies, they now have a default to use.

The second option is to forego minor tests completely. Dice rolls aren't designed to be as common in *Dune* as in many other games. So instead of making a test to pick each lock, make a single test to 'enter the facility'. The more wide-ranging the action, the more important the test and the easier to determine motivation and drive. This method also makes more sense to take time on each roll, as it defines so much.

## USING THE RULES SYSTEM

The *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium* rules are designed to offer a toolbox of flexible options you can apply to match the style of your group. Some people prefer fast-and-loose gameplay, others like a complex and more simulationist approach. Others still prefer for roleplaying and narrative to take precedence over the rules.

The 2d20 rules system offers essentially four ways to resolve any action:

- ✧ **Simple Test:** For when you only need to know if something passed or failed.
- ✧ **Contested Test:** When the action is opposed by someone or something.
- ✧ **Extended Test:** When completing the action takes time, and time is a factor.
- ✧ **Conflict:** When the contest is especially complicated involving multiple characters, a complex situation, or simply deserves more detail.

While some of these forms of test are better suited to different situations, they can apply to any action if the group prefers. Which you pick defines the options for



the narrative, the focus on the action, and how complicated the test is.

Imagine the player characters must interrogate a group of servants to find an assassin. There are already many ways they can go about this, from sitting each of them in a room to following them to see who they talk to or even searching their rooms for clues. They might even try all of them. Let's say this group elects to try and talk casually to each of them and see what they discover. The gamemaster can use any of the systems described above, to the following outcomes:

- ❖ **Simple Test:** The gamemaster tells the players it will take all day to chat to the servants. Each character makes a simple test against a Difficulty based on how clever or well-hidden the assassin is. If any of them succeed, they have found a suspect. This method is simple and quick, but perhaps a little too simple and quick for such an endeavor.
- ❖ **Contested Test:** As above, the gamemaster tells the players this will take all day for all of them to talk to everyone. But they might instead get each player to pick which servants their character is talking to. Each player makes a contested test (either for all the servants together or each one they interview). As this is contested, the gamemaster needs to give each servant (or the servants as a group) a basic drive/skill level for their rolls. Players and the gamemaster spend Threat and Momentum and play out a cat-and-mouse interrogation, where winning reveals if the servant can be trusted (or if there is an assassin in the group). Depending on the number of servants this might be a more satisfying option, but only if finding the assassin is an important part of the adventure.
- ❖ **Extended Test:** This is best for a time limit, such as if the player characters needing to root out the assassin before the ruler of their House arrives. The gamemaster sets a requirement and each roll the player characters make represents a day of questioning. During each roll, the gamemaster and players can describe what actions they might be taking as they follow clues to uncover the assassin. When they run out of time they have either made the requirement and found the villain, or have run out of time and must figure out how to keep their ruler safe while an assassin is on the premises. This option works best if there is a time constraint. Otherwise, the player characters can just keep going until they find what they are after, with few consequences.
- ❖ **Conflict:** For this option the gamemaster needs more statistics for the various non-player characters, although again, it depends which conflict system they use. Intrigue is probably best, with each servant being a zone and the player characters moving

assets to defeat them in a challenge. Each defeated servant reveals whether they can be trusted or not. But the assassin can also move assets to attack the player characters. The player characters won't know who is moving the assets against them, but might be able use the movement of assets as a clue to target their own investigation. This system allows for a lot of complex maneuvering and plotting that may take the whole game session, or possibly longer.

So, as you can see, each type of roll has its own strengths and weaknesses. But these are defined not by the rules but by what works for your group. You need not (and should not) stick to only one form of test, as different situations will often require different levels of complexity to offer the players agency and reach a satisfying outcome. But you can tend towards simple or complex depending on the need and desires of your group. This is especially the case if not everyone prefers the same thing. Some players hate rolling dice and using rules, others can't get enough of it. So, make sure everyone gets catered for at some point, especially when it is their character in the spotlight leading the action.

## ADDING NARRATIVE

The rules system just provides a way to determine an outcome, so it needs a little help from everyone to add an exciting narrative dynamic. Doing so also makes longer and more complex tests a lot more interesting and involving. Essentially, adding narrative just means explaining what a character is actually doing when a player rolls the dice. Just saying you move an asset isn't very exciting, but saying you are flying your ornithopter low over the desert to avoid the spotter drones is much more interesting.

Adding narrative isn't just for the broad strokes either. When a player spends Momentum or gives the gamemaster Threat, they should say what that represents. "I'm spending a Momentum point as I catch the eye of the noble across the room and realize he's going to back me up as I make my play" or "I'm going to add a point of Threat to the gamemaster's pool as my character isn't taking much care to look around as they launch themselves into the attack".

These narrative flourishes improve the game dramatically and generate more detail about the situation that helps develop the story. However, it is important to remember that not everyone is either good or confident at this sort of improvisation. So, while it is great to have more detail, just a simple description is perfectly fine, and it's all right for other players to make suggestions for a scene to help each other out. If someone has trouble adding narration, let them roll the dice and move on. Hopefully, in time they gradually gain more confidence or have some ideas when they see how everyone else is doing it.

## MANAGING SOCIAL CONFLICT & INTRIGUE

Social interaction is one of the most complicated parts of a roleplaying game. As the name implies, roleplaying should encourage playing a role, and that means social interaction should have little or no dice rolling. Leave everything to the player's natural ability to deceive, persuade, and convince, and leave it at that. However, not everyone has the same social skills, and this penalizes those who are quiet and shy or just not natural talkers. They may also want to play a charming socialite character and if everything is roleplay-based, they are at a significant disadvantage.

So, *Dune's* intrigue and social interaction systems level the playing field. They allow the success of a character to be determined by their character's abilities, not the player's. But by adding narrative, you can still let the scene be guided by the roleplaying. Let the players talk and interact with non-player characters between dice tests, but call for a roll to discover what the result of the conversation or plot was.

If you have a group where everyone is an actor, then you can throw away more of the system and focus on the roleplaying aspects. However, it is rare to find a group where that is the case for everyone, so pay attention to timid players and allow the system to help them get the results their character deserves.

## MANAGING CONFLICT, DUELS AND WARS

Conflicts are an inevitable result of House machinations. In some cases, these manifest as personal duels, at other times they escalate into assassination, and sometimes into all-out war. Combat can be exciting and dynamic, but it can also be rules-heavy, and therefore slow. As gamemaster, you should consider what the group prefers when introducing and managing any form of conflict.

Duels are quite common in the Imperium, so the personal combat system allows you to focus on a single fight, such as Paul's duel with Jamis, or later with Feyd in the novel *Dune*. Skirmishes often come about when minor characters try to challenge or oppose the player characters, or as part of an espionage operation, especially when it goes wrong. These sorts of fights are probably the most common form of conflict. Outright war is rare, as it usually requires the Spacing Guild's assistance to move battlefield weapons from planet to planet to reach their objective.

As with any rules system, it is important to apply the correct one, and remember who is involved. A duel only involves two people. So, unless it is hugely important, or the rest of the group are invested in it

to some degree, it's advisable to keep it short. The same goes for skirmish and warfare if not everyone has a stake in the fight. Having said that, any character can become more involved in any conflict without picking up a weapon. They can distract opponents, offer support, or even make bets on who the victor will be! So, the gamemaster should still ask what even less involved characters might like to do when a fight breaks out.

The key thing to remember with any fight is context. A fight on any level should mean something. When Paul fights Jamis, it is a struggle to prove himself to the Fremen. How Paul behaved in the fight and the after-effects on his character and relationship with Stilgar's tribe reverberate throughout the rest of the novel. The skirmishes led by Muad'Dib on spice production cause the Emperor to travel to Arrakis, and the great battle at the end of the novel decides the fate of the universe. So, while combat can be fun and exciting, make sure there is something important at stake, even if it is just the lives of the player characters.

## TROUBLESHOOTING

Cynically, one might argue that no story crafted by a gamemaster survives contact with the players. While you may have an idea how a game session will go, the session is likely to run into challenges beyond any the gamemaster could have anticipated. Let's look at some common solutions.

### ADJUST POWER LEVELS ON THE FLY

Finding the right balance between a game that is both fun and challenging is, in and of itself, a challenge. A game too difficult for the players may frustrate them, while too easy a game will undoubtedly bore them. You can adjust difficulty using Momentum and Threat. If the players are chewing their way through Sardaukar with ease, you can use more dice from the Threat pool to make your antagonists tougher. On the other hand, if your players are having difficulty dealing with some low-grade spice smugglers, you can give them a chance to gain Momentum.

Another idea is to have several non-player character sheets on hand, built at various power levels. If player characters enter combat against a Harkonnen platoon, but you're unsure how they'll fare, you can bring two sets of antagonists to the table. Build the first platoon with beginner-level skills, a single talent, and a single asset. Build the second platoon with a few additional skills, multiple talents, and multiple assets. A selection of beginner-level archetypes can be found in **Chapter 9: Allies and Adversaries**.

A third possibility is to introduce a non-player character who can directly assist the players. Perhaps a Ginaz Swordmaster protects them for a short time, or maybe a

Fremen warrior chooses to guide them out of the deep desert. Serving as a set of training wheels, this non-player character can keep the group alive long enough for them to figure out how to use their skills. After serving their purpose, you can sacrifice the non-player character for the good of the story, or take them off the board to be reintroduced later.

### KEEP THE GAME MOVING

Sometimes players, through no fault of their own, fixate on the wrong thing. You may describe a scene, adding some detail players misinterpret as being vital to the story. Before you know it, they've spent an hour tracking down the provenance of an Albe oil painting which only you know is insignificant. Another twist happens when you present a challenge, and instead of attacking the problem as you imagined, players head in an entirely new (and unprepared for) direction.

One way to mitigate this is to explain, at the start of the story, where the boundaries lie. If the game only takes place on Arrakis, you should feel free to say so. If the players pursue a false lead that would take them off-world, you can remind them of the boundaries established at the start.

Another trick to keep the game on pace is to use a timer, allocating no more than an hour per scene or some equivalent thereof. Basic or unnecessary scenes can be handwaved. And you shouldn't abuse this tactic too much as players like to feel free to make their own decisions. Regardless of how long the scene takes, before you move on to the next, you should make a habit of offering one last request for actions. "Is there anything else you would like to do before we proceed?" is generally a good question to ask.

If you have a non-player character assisting player characters, they can also guide the story on track. The non-player character can offer advice on how best to proceed or warn the characters if they are straying too far from the planned scenario.

That said, if players appear invested in the aforementioned painting or a random side trip, you can develop a plot in the downtime between sessions to highlight their work or tie it in to add further complexity to your planned story.

### ANTICIPATE WILY PLAYERS

While you should have a good idea of where you're headed with the story, you should also anticipate player creativity. A gamemaster cannot plan for every eventuality, and you'll need to be flexible in the face of clever players. When a player takes the game in an unexpected direction, consider their action. This may mean taking the entire story to an unexpected place, or this might mean discouraging the idea and returning them to the primary thrust of the story.

The key is to note what the players seem most interested in doing. If you planned for a combat-heavy campaign, but the players have used every opportunity to circumvent violent encounters, you may want to adjust your expectations and storyline. In other words, if the players are having fun exploring the setting in an unexpected way, you can encourage them while improvising on the fly.

Also, don't hesitate to ask the players why they did something. Their answers can reveal their motivations and provide insight on which clues they'll gravitate toward in future scenes.

### TOTAL PARTY KILL

Sometimes games simply go awry. Maybe the player characters are too stubborn, or the antagonists they're fighting are too overpowered. With no luck from the dice, player characters might be on the verge of a 'total party kill', which grinds the game to an immediate halt. When this happens, you may want to ask the players what they would like to do.

Your goal should be creating a collaborative environment rather than a gamemaster versus player competition. So, don't be afraid to talk about solutions as a group. Listen to the preferences of the players and see if you can come to a compromise that offers them agency in the story even if that means losing a character.

Remember that the members of a House are valuable to that House and may be more useful as captives or bargaining chips, taken prisoner rather than slain outright. They may be ransomed back to the House in return for some concession or favor or may awaken in confinement with an opportunity to escape and learn more about the nature of their enemies. A scene that ends with the apparent death of the entire group may cut to one where they awaken in a medical bay, being tended to by a Suk doctor in the employ of their apparent killers.

Some players may want a mulligan, a second chance at the dice or resetting the scene to start again. Others might be comfortable with the loss because now, having played the game, they want to change their concept. Player character death can be a rewarding part of the campaign but should usually involve options for continuing with your story.



## MANAGING PERSONALITIES

Players are people, and every person has preferences, opinions, and quirks. One person's preference may come into conflict with someone else's opinion. In this way, as a gamemaster, not only are you in charge of managing the story, but you may also need to manage the personalities of the players whether that is as a director or a referee. Remember, you want to foster a collaborative atmosphere where everyone can have fun playing.

### DEALING WITH THE RULES

There is a general misconception that a gamemaster needs to have every rule memorized. This is simply not the case—this is why the book exists. When the players face a challenge, you serve as a referee for the rules, which may require interpretation from time to time. If they have a question, you can quickly review the rules, consult the players, and decide. Some players, however, focus entirely on the rules, reviewing every word or sentence, upsetting the flow of the game. If you cannot convince this player of the merits of your interpretation, and if you cannot appeal to their sense of mutual cooperation, then the easiest solution is to turn to the entire room and solve rules disputes with a majority vote.

### HANDLING DISENGAGEMENT

If a player spends more time focused on their phone than on what is happening around the table, then you should address this. The player may be bored, or perhaps they don't know how to interact with the game and don't want to embarrass themselves by asking. The simplest way to address disengaged players is to ask them directly what they would like to do with their character. If they're unsure, ask them open-ended questions. How does their player character feel about this situation? Does the player character have any assets that might help the group? Making sure that everyone has an opportunity to take part is the best way to keep players invested in the overall story.

With devices in specific, some game tables employ a 'no phones' rule. Everyone can agree to keep their phones in their pockets, or you can leave a bowl out for everyone to put their phones in until the end of the game session.

A more dramatic and adversarial method is to add a point of Threat to the gamemaster's pool every time a player uses a phone at the table for anything other than what might be supported by the game. However, this is not always fair: it may be that the player has some personal issue that needs close attention. It's always better to ask than to assume.

### REDUCING DISTRACTIONS

Distracted players are different from disengaged players—they're present but are more interested in socializing than playing. Socializing is important to a game, but too much can sap the game's flow. One solution is to schedule periodic breaks during a game and limiting non-related conversation to those periods. Another idea is to employ a timer. If your players are prone to idle chit-chat, set the timer for five minutes. When it goes off, gameplay must resume. If the timer goes off too many times during a game session, you can always introduce a random encounter to grab everyone's attention, taken in the form of a failing generator, a Sardaukar platoon, or perhaps even wormsign!

### INTEGRATING LONERS

If most of the players want to do one thing while a lone operator wants to do something else, that's perfectly acceptable. Side adventures and risk takers can, at times, present new and interesting opportunities. But when that lone operator decides to raid the Arrakeen Residency on their own, and ends up getting captured, that is likely unhelpful. Players are not only responsible for their own enjoyment and wellbeing, but also for their fellow players' fun, too. The easiest solution for this is to occasionally check in with the players to make sure that everyone is all on the same page and working toward the same goal.

However, when a player is monopolizing the gamemaster's attention, or their actions become more of a distraction than a help, it might be time to talk to that player privately. After the session wraps and people are getting ready to leave, ask if the problem player can stick around for a few more minutes. Remain calm and keep the conversation friendly, but do your best to explain the issue and work with the player to find solutions. Most of the time you'll find saying something to the player is enough to curb the behavior.

# CONSENT & COMFORT LEVELS

A roleplaying game requires trust between everyone taking part, including a gamemaster with their players and between the individual players. Communication builds that trust. Players have different preferences and triggers, and it is impossible to predict all of them without talking openly about it first. This is part of what Session 0 (see p.224) is all about.

Session 0 is when you determine what the players are looking for in their experience: here's where they create their characters, to decide on the play-styles, and here is where you can have a conversation about content. While **Dune's** setting is not by its nature controversial, it does involve violence, slavery, oppression, eugenics, genocide, torture, unwilling seduction, etc. Some players might find these issues or concepts problematic.

Using safety tools is not a way to sanitize and dull your game or to police your creativity, but to make sure everyone wants to play the same game. Roleplaying can be a very intimate and intense experience, and a good session can be very affecting. Your gaming sessions should be charged with feeling and emotion, but not to the point where events within them traumatize anyone.

## COMFORT & CONSENT

When talking to your players for the first time, ask about their comfort levels. Ask them what subjects you should avoid in your story. Ask them if they have any strong phobias. Some players do not want to be emotionally abused by a non-player character while others might enjoy it. Some might have a physiological response to detailed descriptions of gore. Another might have a powerful aversion to insects.

If the players are uncomfortable voicing their concerns, you can always create an anonymous survey. Make a list of content themes you intend to include in your story. This might be 'domestic violence', 'gore', 'torture', 'spiders', etc. Assign a rating of 1 through 5 to each of them to denote how likely a player is to interact with the content. A rating of 1 would be unlikely whereas 5 would suggest it's unavoidable. Players can then mark which aspects they don't want to engage in. It's your job to dial back and avoid engaging that player without their consent.

And, if you do this during Session 0, you'll avoid pitfalls like basing a game on Caladan when half of your group is afraid of water. But Session 0 isn't the only time you should talk about consent and content because a player is free to give and take back their consent at any time. People change day-to-day, and our responses to stimuli change. So, you should try to gauge player reactions and check in with them periodically as the story unfolds. It may be that once trust is established, players are more open to some of the issues they may have initially had a problem with.

## MITIGATING PLAYER ABUSE

Players portray characters in a game, but a player who uses their character to conduct themselves in an inappropriate manner can sometimes use their creations as a shield. They might say, "This is how my character would act" to justify their actions. To be fair, you should support your players when they want to explore darker aspects and experiences, but not at the expense of other players. If a player is portraying their character in a way distressing to others, speak to that player privately to discuss how both they, and the other players involved, can cooperate. Avoid criticizing the player but be firm when reinforcing the idea that no single character motivation should supersede the overall emotional safety and enjoyment of the other players.

This applies to gamemaster behavior as well. If you're using a non-player character in a way that makes the players feel uncomfortable, the players must be able to voice their concern. And even if you already alerted players to a content theme in Session 0, it's good practice to ask when it comes up in the game. If you plan to have a scene where a villain tortures one of the player characters, double check to ensure that all the players are still comfortable with the scene taking place.

Often, issues surrounding a game stem from miscommunication rather than malicious intent. So long as everyone is willing to listen to concerns and adjust when necessary, you can resolve most issues swiftly and with cooperation.

## CHECKING IN WITH PLAYERS

As players portray their characters, dramatic and dangerous situations can draw them in. Just like roller coasters or scary movies, fun and excitement can provoke emotional responses. It can be difficult to see when events in a game session are overwhelming for a player, and harder still to tell the difference between the character's reaction versus the player's reaction to something potentially upsetting. And it can be even more difficult for a player in emotional distress to feel comfortable enough to pause a game. They don't want to look like the killjoy, or appear weak, or they may be worried they'll ruin everyone's fun.

As the one in charge, you should keep an eye out for signs of anxiety, call for breaks when necessary, and act as an advocate for players who might be too shy to speak up. To make this easier, the following suggestions are provided to make this easier for everyone.

## ‘OKAY’ CHECK-IN

This system allows players to communicate quickly without interrupting the game. If you or a player worries about someone else’s comfort at the table, instead of stopping the game to ask how they’re doing, you can use an ‘Okay check-in’. Make a thumbs-up sign to the player as a way of subtly asking if the player is comfortable proceeding. The player then responds with a thumbs-up denoting they are comfortable proceeding, a waffling hand suggesting they’re unsure if they should proceed, or with a thumbs-down alerting you that they are not all right. At this point, you can pause the game or allow the player to walk away from the table until you’re past the disturbing content. Sometimes a player just needs to take a break, but you can use the opportunity to have a private conversation with them to check-in on their well-being.

## COLOR CHECK-IN OR STOPLIGHT METHOD

Each player has a colored item such as a dice, token, or badge. Each color is a level of consent. Green for full consent or comfort, yellow stands for caution, and red means ‘stop’ or ‘no’. The game starts with each of the players displaying their green item. As you run the game, the players can swap out or flash their colored items per their level of comfort signaling their consent or lack thereof to a scene’s content.

## SAFE WORD

A final method for checking-in with players is to use a safe word. At Session 0 or the start of game, everyone agrees with a word or phrase, which when said, calls for an immediate five-minute break. If everyone has the freedom to call for a pause, then hopefully everyone feels comfortable using it. As a gamemaster, you can then follow up and ask the player who called the break what aspect of the game they were having difficulty with, if it is not obvious.

# CREATING GAMES IN THE DUNE UNIVERSE

*Dune* can be daunting for any gamemaster to tackle, regardless of their skill or experience. Even answering the question of what makes an authentic ‘*Dune* adventure’ has an almost limitless set of possible answers. For some, *Dune* deals with the tension and interplay of power and freedom. How freedom requires power to secure, but that acquiring power can ultimately limit your own freedom and of course trample on the freedoms of others. For others, it is about ecology and the consequences of exploiting resources, an indictment of capitalism and about the cruelty of feudalism. Others still might find it an evocative science-fictional adventure story set in a challenging environment.

A **Dune** adventure or campaign may even illustrate how prophecy and prescience further complicate the very definition of freedom, and how that power comes in many forms including but not limited to economic manipulation, religious dogma, genetic engineering and psychosocial conditioning. This depth can seem impossible to grasp in a way that’s authentic to the source material, yet it gives players an experience that matches up with their expectations, and lets you have fun with your friends at the same time.

As with many complex settings, such depth creates a tension that arises from the urge to present a gaming experience that encapsulates everything that *Dune* has to offer. This is a trap and an illusion. Larger themes can be distilled in small and fleeting moments, even if they never take the spotlight in your campaign. More importantly, the gamemaster’s choice to create an adventure

or campaign that focuses on one theme or setting element above all others is not only a valid choice but a necessary one. Part of creating a memorable adventure or setting is determining what to emphasize as well as what to de-emphasize, or ignore outright.

This is further complicated by the hyper-awareness and preternatural introspection that is almost commonplace among the accomplished humans who are likely to stand against your player characters. A multitude of factors, such as the geriatric spice and the lack of thinking machines, have produced a setting filled with humans possessed of unnaturally long life, intense mental discipline, and weaponized emotional intelligence. While these superhuman qualities make them formidable foes and valuable allies, at their core they remain human and vulnerable to irrational and reckless choices when their core identity is challenged or threatened. Duncan Idaho, for example, is a peerless Swordmaster, the equal of any Sardaukar, but when confronted with a conflict of loyalties between his liege Leto and Leto’s consort, Jessica, he becomes despondent and lashes out rashly.

## MOVING BETWEEN ARCHITECTS & AGENTS

Identifying what elements of the setting the story will focus on not only helps clarify what kind of characters will prosper in your story, it will also open the possibilities of how your players transition between the architect and agent modes of play. These two modes of play allow players to choose between their player characters

acting directly as agents or pulling the strings behind the curtain as architects.

As an agent, a character is in the right place at the right time. They can directly manipulate events and have more options to change their approach in the mission. However, they are directly in harm's way. If a mission fails, they might be captured or worse. When opting to work as an architect, a character has less direct control over how the mission plays out. But they are also for the most part insulated from its failures.

As the gamemaster, you need not worry which mode is being used at any time, as they apply mainly at each player's whim. Which mode you are using depends mainly on the assets being used. If the asset is equipment, the player character probably needs to be present as an agent. But if the asset is a group or an agent, they are probably being given their orders from afar by an architect. If you are ever confused, just ask the player which mode they would like to be in. But remind them that it is hard to change their mind once the mission is underway! The player characters need not all be in the same mode either. Some might act as agents breaking into a complex while another remains at their base monitoring and using other agents to cause a distraction for the complex's defenses.

Depending on what they are doing, player characters can move between each mode. If they send in a group of soldiers to fight the Harkonnen and everything goes wrong, they might be close enough to follow the soldiers as agents. But if they are giving orders from their home planet or a far away control center, that is rarely possible. Remember that when using architect mode, each architect only has the assets they have in play. Many simply allow the architect to act, rather than grant a bonus, given they are not present. But acting through assets can be just as devastating as being on the front line.

In a story highlighting grand political intrigue, a scene of a few shadowy conspirators plotting against their foes can seamlessly fade into a scene that plays through the most critical parts of their scheme. You could even weave one scene into the other using flashbacks and 'flashforwards', possibly even blurring the lines of which scene occurs in the past and which is in the present. This structure touches upon the themes of hyper-perception and predeterminism but requires a great deal of trust between players and the gamemaster.

Most of the time, scenes are linear, with architect-level play dominating at the onset then, if appropriate, agent-level gameplay coming to the fore. They can alternate, but the transition from one dominant mode of play to another is generally easiest to achieve and less jarring for players. However, creativity is required to make sure that each player is given their time to shine even if their role in the plan itself is less dynamic. Confronting them

with unforeseen complications and exploiting their hidden motivations to create dramatic moments that can jeopardize their goals and the safety of their friends. This is especially important when dealing with otherwise routine sequences where each character may have a nearly-identical task to perform. Breaking these up with unexpected twists or dramatic interludes can keep gameplay fresh and engaging for everyone at the table.

## EVOKING THE POWER OF FAITH

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Faith and religion are often central to *Dune*, especially the exploration of the differences between the two. Throughout the Imperium and its history, faith is cynically exploited for political purposes, regardless of the potential consequences. Religion itself is often portrayed as deliberate social engineering of peoples' beliefs to the advantage of groups of such as the Bene Gesserit Sisterhood, or even the Spacing Guild with its secrecy and traditions.

Honest expressions of faith or religion certainly have their place within the Imperium, but a tenet of the setting is that all things that drive humans to action must be examined or they can become dangerous. Blind faith and dogmatic religions are twisted by heroes and villains alike to achieve their selfish ends, but without faith there can be no progress on the Golden Path toward enlightenment. Despite its cynical exploitation, religion often has a positive role when it unites people towards a common purpose against chaos and ruin.

When incorporating elements of faith and religion into their stories, you should try to balance these meta-narratives implicit in the setting against the characters that experience these concepts as authentic expressions of themselves and their beliefs.

*An adventure or campaign that incorporates a myth planted by the Missionaria Protectiva into a local religion does not invalidate the faith the characters feel within that religious system. It only illustrates that humans are often fallible and that they are always tempted to subvert their most sacred creations to further their own material agendas. How the characters react when this myth is used against their interests is where the drama of the narrative develops. Do they find a way to cling to their faith while rejecting a dogma that is leading them to ruin, or do they accept that their identity is too tied to the institutional practice of their faith to avoid the traps set for them? Both choices are dramatic and allow the player characters to explore their own internal dynamics in a contest with the outside forces pitted against them. Regardless of the outcome, their faith is tested and their understanding of that facet of themselves can be altered as well.*

## PORTRAYING THE GALACTIC SCALE

Just as *Dune* can be imposing in its depth, the breadth of that the Imperium, encompassing a vast galactic empire, poses unique challenges in the form of its scale. This scale serves its epic themes perfectly, illustrating the unseen patterns of human lives and individual choices can have lasting impact on all of creation.

The availability of nearly instantaneous interstellar travel may suggest adventures where adventurers solve problems and then move on to the next solar system, but this structure plays against the strengths of the setting. *Dune* lends itself to epic stories that focus on individuals and their exertion of will against a seemingly predeterministic universe. Much like the characters, planets themselves are multidimensional and composed of unique and competing political, economic, and environmental factors.

*Arrakis is not just a desert planet populated by warrior nomads. Though it is often misrepresented in that way, it is arguably the fulcrum of the Imperium's geopolitical and economic power: the source of spice, the commodity that fuels and sustains the the entire galactic civilization. Because of that, its native population's desire for self-determination is ignored, as Imperial factions vie for control of the planet's irreplaceable resource. Arrakis itself is a character, and while its peculiar geography, creatures and resources are important, it is how humans interact with those peculiarities that create drama.*

A major aspect of *Dune* as a setting is that it's about people and their place in the universe, and how their struggles are more often determined by how they confront internal conflicts than by which planet they happen to be standing upon.

As the gamemaster, you should be willing to explore the setting beyond Arrakis, but understand that just like Arrakis, every planet brings with it a depth beyond scenery or a single note of drama. Caladan, the beloved ocean planet of House Atreides, is more than just a contrast to Arrakis' desert. Caladan is the counterpoint of the familiar to the Atreides once they arrive on Arrakis, forcing them to adapt and ultimately change the universe in the process. Where Caladan represented the fully realized center of their old power, Arrakis embodies the potential seed of their new power. In the tension between these two worlds, and in what the Atreides bring with them both materially and psychologically from the old to the new, is the story of their struggle, triumph and apotheosis.

## THE CHALLENGES OF TECHNOLOGY

Often, advanced technology can create a challenge within a game, as miraculous devices can suddenly negate all the familiar obstacles that usually confront player characters. To some degree the setting negates many of these concerns: few are the problems in the Imperium that can be solved solely by the application of technology, and the reliance upon technology itself is a cautionary tale around which the entire Imperium was founded. If anything, unchecked use of technology has proven time and again to be ruinous, as demonstrated in the history of the Imperium, or deleterious to the soul, such as is embodied by the 'detestable' and technocratic Tleilaxu.

The unique elements of *Dune*'s setting creates new dynamics and challenges. Body shields produced by Holtzman generators reduce the effectiveness and ubiquity of powerful ranged weapons, meaning most action not on the battlefield will be up close and personal. The Butlerian Jihad and later religious proscription has eradicated the use of thinking machines, so many advanced computational tasks require dedicated and highly trained specialists. Without its dependence on machines humans expanded their own capabilities, some even honing skills bordering on the supernatural.

Thus, despite all of the titanic monsters, genetic engineering, and mind-bending powers, the Imperium embodies a very human future. Humankind and its capacity for both reason and recklessness is at its center. It is in the hands of humans that these great powers become either the path to a golden future or to the dreadful arafel, the cloud-darkness at the end of the universe.



## PROPHECY, PRESCIENCE, & HYPER-PERCEPTION

Most formidable and iconic of all human abilities in *Dune* is prescience. This capability is often referred to as prophecy, because of the mystical and religious significance it has to many cultures and societies. The Bene Gesserit's Kwisatz Haderach, the confluence and goal of their immense breeding program, is perhaps the most obvious expression of a foretold prophet. However, this quasi-mystical being is also a result of paradox, foretelling of a so-called 'messiah' that is the result of century after century of overt political manipulation and planned eugenics.

## RESPECTING PEOPLE & THEIR CULTURES

The Imperium is both recognizably human but also beyond humanity as we know it today. Here is a universe filled with people that are obviously of Earth though set in a future so distant that this origin is lost and obscured. To accomplish this, *Dune* draws heavily from many different real human cultures, languages, and religions. In a few cases these real-world elements are used unmodified, but for the most part they are altered in an attempt to portray human culture as ever-evolving. Not just physical evolution, but psychosocially and spiritually evolving.

Quasi-Arabic words are sprinkled throughout the Fremen language and religious movements. The Zensunni are clearly intended to be melded evolutions of Islamic and Buddhist spirituality. Most telling is the use of the word 'jihad', usually meaning 'struggle' or 'strife' in Arabic, usually towards a noble purpose. This term is liberally used throughout the novels, but strictly in the context of a holy war, an emotionally loaded concept in the modern world.

It can be tempting to make assumptions about Zensunni or Fremen thought based on one's understanding of Buddhism or Middle-Eastern culture, but this was neither the author's original intent nor is it the purpose of this game.

When evoking and utilizing these aspects of the setting, it is important to remember they were meant as a shorthand for the unlimited capacity of humankind to create, adapt, and survive as it spreads across the galaxy, but also to continue tradition of belief, uninterrupted across even greater spans of time. Ideas that seem opposed or antithetical to each other today may be destined to align and grow into something more profound still. That is a powerful and ultimately positive statement, and thus it is advised that the concepts and beliefs from which these game concepts grew should be treated with respect. Thus, it is advised to use utmost care if turning to real-world cultures, ethnicities, and religions for inspiration, rather than presenting them as mere source material to be drawn from and inadvertently exploited or portrayed disrespectfully.

## THE PROBLEM OF PRESCIENCE

Even Muad'Dib himself doubts his divinity and is often paralyzed by his own vision of a future he cannot accept but simultaneously feels powerless to avert. This is the limit and danger of prophecy. The patterns of possibility open before one. To reach a desired future one must cleave to a rigid path, but also be ever aware of the cresting waveform of the present—always adjusting to the minutiae of circumstance or risk falling off the path and into unintended chaos. The power of prophecy thus limits personal freedom, and the path to the future can quickly become a trap to which one must willingly fall victim or risk arriving at an unknown and potentially undesirable destination.

This is further complicated by the more practical and subtle uses of prescience as a method of surveillance. At its most extreme, seeing prescient patterns and outcomes can mean an almost omniscient ability to see and foresee the actions of allies and enemies alike. This is particularly dangerous if these powers are a closely-held secret, as the best defenses against prescience require foreknowledge of such a capability.

## AVOIDING PRESCIENCE

As gamemaster, you should understand how such capabilities will distort the outcome of events in a story and how both player characters and non-player characters alike will react to such capabilities. While certain means of avoiding prescience—the presence of Guild Navigators or later technology such as no-chambers will eventually partly counter it—the most reliable method of countering prophetic power will be the active machinations of other prescient beings. It is often difficult for prescient beings to see and predict outcomes that directly involve the actions of others with this ability. Somehow their ability to observe and interpret the patterns of the future are either themselves variables outside of the larger pattern, or threads within the pattern too subtle for all but the most talented prescient beings to perceive.

Even individuals who are not fully prescient but have the potential for such power, can interfere with a prophet's ability to divine the future. In particular, Guild Navigators are known to disrupt prescient sight in chaotic ways, while unrealized or failed attempts at the Kwisatz Haderach seem to be completely invisible to prophetic sight.

Regardless of the reasons, those that rely too heavily on prophetic abilities risk locking themselves into futures with unforeseen consequences just beyond the edge of their prescience, or they see their carefully-laid plans toppled by the actions of another they could not see. Once this weakness in prophecy is realized, it becomes exploitable by those seeking to defend against prescience. Plotters may seek the presence of a Guild Navigator to cloak their secret meeting, and failed products of the Bene Gesserit breeding program become deadly assassins that even the inner eye cannot see.

## HYPER-PERCEPTION AND EXPANDED CONSCIOUSNESS

Additionally, hyper-perceptive characters can present challenges, especially in games hinging on intrigue and mystery. Advanced machines that emulate the qualities or shape of humankind are considered profane, as is allowing technology said to 'disfigure the soul'. As described extensively in the history depicted within **Chapter 2: The Known Universe**, this prohibition has led to the breeding and training of specialized humans capable of awesome feats of mental calculation, physical prowess, and interpersonal empathy.

Just as human Mentats replace computers, others are trained and shaped to act with inhuman speed or perceive the slightest changes in another's micro-expressions. The elite Imperial Sardaukar of the Padishah Emperor are honed by a secret and brutal training program that makes them into the most feared fighting force in the Imperium. Guild Navigators are perhaps the most profound example of this, being mutated by excessive exposure to spice to force upon them prescience by which they can plot courses across the galaxy.

Finally, the Bene Gesserit Sisterhood uses a carefully monitored breeding program, secret prana-bindu techniques, and precise applications of the mind-expanding spice to create an elite cadre of supernaturally insightful Reverend Mothers. While their prescience is limited, the Bene Gesserit are arguably the most powerful organization in the Imperium before the emergence of the Kwisatz Haderach, in turn a direct result of their machinations.

## GAMEMASTERING SUPERHUMANS

When stories incorporate characters with such superhuman traits, it can be difficult to deal with them in a way that honors their power without disrupting the agency of the other player characters, of retaining any cohesion of the adventure or campaign being played. Political machinations and subtle intrigues are a cornerstone of the setting, and revolutionaries must often navigate a reality that includes human lie detectors such as the Bene Gesserit or act in ways unanticipated by Mentats. The Imperium is not a forgiving setting for amateur conspirators, and intrigues often have layers of measures and countermeasures that are meant to defeat the superhuman abilities of one's rivals. Traps are often set for enemies in such a way that their discovery and defeat begin a sequence of events that bring

misfortune on their foes by the consequences of their own reaction. As the gamemaster, you should keep in mind that the most dangerous individuals in the Imperium are those who have become adept at navigating these threats to their independence. Such foes rarely take the direct route to achieve their goals, preferring the indirect or unexpected routes. An indirect or seemingly unpredictable approach to a goal hides one's true motivations and invites the player characters to defeat themselves with reckless action, potentially exposing their own goals to attack.

*An enemy spy is discovered within the player characters' entourage. While at first this seems like a major coup for the players, how they choose to deal with this spy will determine the true implications of this ploy.*

- *If they simply eliminate the spy, they may anger those who believed she was a loyal servant.*
- *If they interrogate the spy, they may be exposed to false information planted within her memory that could lead down a path of their enemy's choosing.*

*Perhaps the false spy even implicates a trusted ally as a traitor, backed with the certainty of false memories meant specifically to circumvent powers such as hyper-perception or the Voice.*

Intrigues run deep and take on these indirect and labyrinthine routes because humankind has evolved powers capable of piercing the illusion of lesser ploys. Many plots require a sacrifice, a pawn to be captured and left in the power of one's enemies. Then one's true forces can be brought to bear while enemies are distracted. In the most convoluted of these feints, the pawn itself is revealed to be empowered by its proximity to its captors.

Ultimately, for a gamemaster, all these issues should present more opportunity than obstacle. Every action an enemy takes should be treated with distrust, so much so that even the most blatant and superficially obvious ploy is viewed as a potential stratagem whose true nature has yet to be revealed. Such is life within the Imperium for those connected to the noble Houses: always to be on the alert for subterfuge, even when there is none. The most dangerous threat is that which has not yet been perceived, and often it is quite enough to create the illusion of danger, to divert an enemy's attention from one's true purpose.





## CHAPTER 9: ALLIES & ADVERSARIES

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*To attempt an understanding of Muad'Dib without understanding his mortal enemies, the Harkonnens, is to attempt seeing Truth without knowing Falsehood. It is the attempt to see the Light without knowing Darkness. It cannot be.*

*—from “Manual of Muad'Dib” by the Princess Irulan*

# NON-PLAYER CHARACTERS



While Arrakis and the other planets in the Imperium are mysterious and intriguing places, it is the people of *Dune* and their agenda that create the plot and adventure. The machinations of each of the various characters — be it due to greed, hatred, or love — are what drives each encounter and adventure, whether it leads to exultation or tragedy.

In this chapter we offer an array of characters for the gamemaster to use in their campaign, including a selection of 'off-the-rack' non-player characters. However, we begin with detail on the major characters in the initial saga of *Dune*, as they stand at its beginning. They might serve as inspiration for your own characters and non-player characters or even become part of your campaign. You might even play them as characters (but remember their talents currently apply to non-player characters). In your campaign, it will be up to you to decide if they become allies or adversaries of your player characters' House. They may follow their established destiny, but it is equally possible their fate may be changed by their encounter with your player characters.

Minor and Notable NPCs are created in the same way as Supporting characters of the same rank (see p.136-137). They use Momentum and Determination in a different way (see below) and instead of picking a Talent may instead choose from the NPC Special Abilities (see table on p.328).

## NPCs: MOMENTUM, & DETERMINATION

For reasons of keeping gameplay moving, non-player characters do not quite follow the same rules as player characters.

Commonly, non-player characters (at least, those in need of stats and making skill tests) operate as opponents to the player characters. The non-player characters in this chapter have been written under that assumption. Rather than spending Momentum, their abilities spend points of Threat from the gamemaster's pool. Remember that non-player characters can save their unused Momentum as Threat.

If you have a non-player character used as an ally to the players, their abilities spend Momentum instead, though they can only use Momentum from the group pool if the players agree to it.

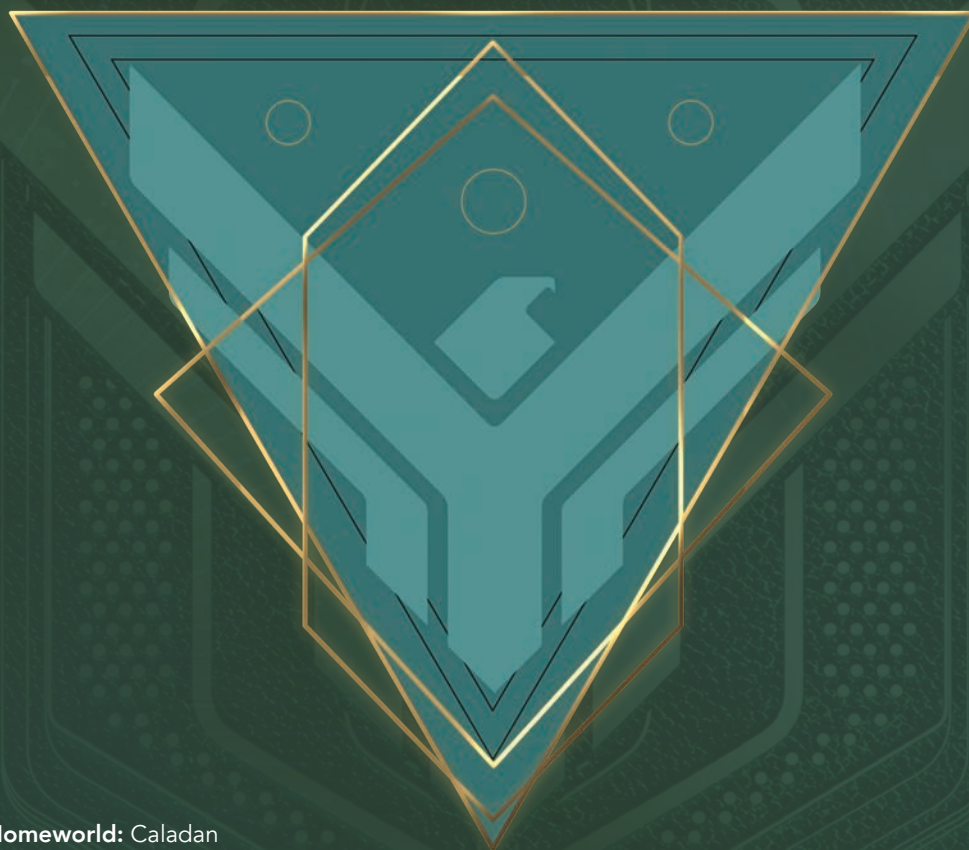
Non-player characters do not have Determination as do player characters. Instead, a non-player character adds 3 points to Threat whenever they

would gain a point of Determination, and they may spend 3 Threat to gain the benefits of spending a point of Determination. The non-player characters in this chapter have had some abilities altered to reflect this.

Finally, non-player characters do not typically have a reason to Obtain Information as players do. The gamemaster is likely to be much more knowledgeable about a situation than the non-player characters are, but should attempt to role-play non-player characters based on the knowledge they possess. However, non-player characters can still use Obtain Information to know information about the player characters, often as a prompt to call out details about them. With particularly observant characters, such as Bene Gesserit and Mentats, this may allow the gamemaster to ask the players for their characters' thoughts and feelings, or even secrets about them.

# HOUSE ATREIDES

## HOUSE MAJOR



**Homeworld:** Caladan

**Other Holdings:** None

**Banners and Arms:** **Colors:** Green & Black  
**Crest:** Hawk

**House Traits:** Honorable, Popular

**Primary Domains:** Farming (Produce) – Pundi Rice

**Secondary Domains:** Farming (Produce) – Moonfish, Military (Expertise) Tacticians, Instructors, Political (Understanding) – Negotiation

House Atreides is one of the oldest and most respected Houses of the Landsraad. While it is not the most powerful, it has carved out an important niche in the Imperium. It has not been responsible for many powerful victories since distinguishing itself at the Battle of Corrin — but it has never really taken any steps backward, managing a slow and steady rise to power.

The main export of House Atreides is a crop called ‘pundi rice’. This rice is both nutritious and travels well and given the fair price the Atreides charge it has become a staple food for most of the Imperium. This focus on a minor (but now ubiquitous) farming crop, rather than military might or deadly poisons, has also made the Atreides seem less threatening to the other Houses. This has allowed them to make many friends among the Imperium and secure several allies.

Sadly, the rise in popularity of House Atreides has not gone unnoticed. The Emperor has come to fear that the Atreides might soon have enough allies to be able to challenge House Corrino for the throne. This has driven the Emperor to begin a plot to destroy House Atreides, using their old enemy, House Harkonnen.